Lesson 19: Purpose, Audience, Tone and Content

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 3.2: Purpose, Audience, Tone, and Content; 3.3: Writing Paragraphs (Exercises).

In this lesson

You will learn the four common academic purposes for writing (to summarize, analyze, synthesize and evaluate) and how your audience and tone shape the content of a paragraph. You will identify the purpose and audience of model paragraphs, describe a writer's tone, and plan two different paragraphs on the same topic. In a psychology course, the verb in an assignment ("summarize this study", "evaluate this theory") tells you exactly what kind of writing is expected.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify the four common academic purposes and the assignment verbs that signal them.
- Describe an audience by its demographics, education, prior knowledge and expectations.
- Recognize a writer's tone and the devices that create it.
- Choose content that suits your purpose, audience and tone.
- Write two topic sentences with the same main idea but different controlling ideas, and explain how the paragraphs would differ.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
purpose	the reason the writer composes a text; it answers the question "Why?"	Why write instructions to the babysitter? To inform him or her of your schedule and rules.
audience	the person or group the writer intends to address	a group of college classmates; a group of high school students
tone	the writer's attitude toward the subject or the reader	excited, humorous, somber, critical
content	all the written substance in a document	examples, statistics, facts, anecdotes, testimonies and observations
summarize	shrink a long text into only the essentials, in your own words	a few sentences about a two-hour film
analyze	separate something into its parts and study how the parts relate	sodium and chloride in table salt

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
synthesize	combine main points from two or more texts into a new point	a synthesizer blends instruments into a new sound
evaluate	judge the value of something and give reasons	a supervisor's employee evaluation
primary source	the original document that you analyze	an essay, a book, an article
demographics	data about a group, such as age range, ethnicity, religious beliefs or gender	Consider demographics when you begin to think about your purpose.
prior knowledge	what the audience already knows about your topic	A nursing major would presumably know more about health-related topics than a business major would.
expectations	what readers look for while reading	correct grammar, traditional formatting, content that matches the title
succinct	short, clear and to the point	Summary paragraphs should be succinct.
formal / informal language	careful, neutral wording / casual, conversational wording	"I volunteered at a local hospital." / "OMG! You won't believe this!"

Rules and explanations

One paragraph, one main idea

One long block of text is hard to follow. Paragraphs separate ideas into logical, manageable chunks: each paragraph focuses on one main idea, so begin a new paragraph for each new idea. Three elements shape the content of every paragraph: **purpose** (why you write), **audience** (whom you write for) and **tone** (your attitude to the subject).

The four academic purposes

Purpose	What the paragraph does	The book's everyday comparison
Summary	Condenses a long text into only the vital information, in the writer's own words. It keeps all the key points and key support but is shorter.	telling a friend about a film in a few sentences
Analysis	Takes apart a primary source point by point and shows how the points relate to one another.	studying how sodium and chloride combine in table salt
Synthesis	Links the main points of two or more texts to create a new point that is not in either text.	a synthesizer blending a piano, a flute and a guitar into a new sound

Purpose	What the paragraph does	The book's everyday comparison
Evaluation	Judges the value of a text or topic: your opinion and its justifications. It needs summary, analysis and synthesis skills, so it often follows them.	a supervisor rating an employee's performance

Tip: in assignment instructions, look for the verbs *summarize, analyze, synthesize* and *evaluate*. In a psychology course, for example, you might summarize one study, analyze how an experiment was designed, synthesize the findings of several studies, or evaluate a theory.

Audience

Imagine giving the same presentation first to college classmates and then to high school students. For the second group you would simplify the charts, define the terms and perhaps dress more casually. Writing works the same way, even though readers are "invisible". The book's two hospital paragraphs show this: the same weekend is described for two different readers. Think about four traits of your readers:

- **Demographics:** age range, ethnicity, religious beliefs, gender.
- **Education:** readers with a doctorate may need a more formal style; college students accept a more relaxed one. Their major also matters.
- **Prior knowledge:** what they already know decides which terms you define and which concepts you explain.
- **Expectations:** correct grammar, traditional format (double spacing, a legible font) and content that matches the title.

Grammar is the "appearance" of your writing: like messy hair at a speech, errors distract readers from your message.

Tone

Tone is the writer's attitude toward a subject or a person. Speakers show it with their voice; writers show it with **sentence structure, word choice, punctuation, and formal or informal language**. Tone can range from excited and humorous to somber and critical, and it must always match the audience and the purpose.

Content

Content may consist of examples, statistics, facts, anecdotes, testimonies and observations. Whatever its type, it must be appropriate and interesting for the audience and purpose, and it should match the tone. An essay that summarizes the legislative process for third graders, for example, needs simple, succinct content and an enthusiastic tone.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - You already switch between formal Modern Standard Arabic and everyday spoken dialect. English has a similar difference between academic and informal registers: compare the two hospital paragraphs, and keep chat-style features (OMG, slang, words in capitals for emphasis, many exclamation marks) out of academic writing.

Practice

Exercise 1. Purpose. Read the paragraphs about films in the lesson material ("This film could easily have been cut down ...", "During the opening scene ...", "To create the feeling of being gripped in a vice ..."). Identify the purpose of each paragraph: summary, analysis, synthesis or evaluation. (The book says "four films", but only three paragraphs are printed.)

Exercise 2. Audience. Read the two hospital paragraphs in the lesson material ("Last Saturday, I volunteered at a local hospital ..." and "OMG! You won't believe this! ...").

1. Which paragraph would the author send to her parents, and which to her best friend?
2. Name three features of the second paragraph that show its audience.

Exercise 3. Tone. Read the paragraph on wildlife conservation ("Many species of plants and animals are disappearing right before our eyes ...").

1. How would you describe the writer's attitude toward wildlife conservation?
2. Which words and devices create this tone?
3. What is the writer's purpose?

Exercise 4. Same main idea, different controlling idea (lesson material 3.3, Exercise 1). Choose one topic: working part-time while attending college; health care reform; introducing a four-day work week; bringing pets to work; taking on-line classes; or a psychology topic such as sleep and memory. Write a topic sentence with a main idea and a controlling idea. Then write an alternative topic sentence with the same main idea but a different controlling idea. Explain how the two fully developed paragraphs might differ in tone and content.

Exercise 5. Analyse a paragraph (lesson material 3.3, Exercise 2, done alone). Use the reality TV paragraph from Lesson 18 ("After reading the new TV guide this week ..."). Answer the book's questions:

1. Is the topic sentence clearly identifiable or is it implied?
2. Do all the supporting sentences relate to the topic sentence?
3. Does the writer use effective transitions to link his or her ideas?
4. Does the concluding sentence accurately summarize the main point of the paragraph?
5. Who is the audience, and what is the tone? (This question applies this lesson.)

Speak with your tutor

- "Write four short paragraphs about one psychology study: a summary, an analysis, a synthesis and an evaluation, in a random order. I will identify each purpose and explain my choice."
- "Role-play: you are a high school student who has never studied psychology. I will explain the difference between short-term and long-term memory. Stop me when I use a term you do not know. Then be a psychology professor, and I will explain it again in a more formal style."
- "Here are my two topic sentences from Exercise 4: [paste]. Do they have the same main idea and different controlling ideas? How would the tone and content of the two paragraphs differ?"

- "Check my answers to Exercises 1, 2 and 3 in the lesson material."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each |.

1. In academic settings, | the reasons for writing fulfill these main purposes: | to summarize, | to analyze, | to synthesize, | and to evaluate.
2. A summary shrinks a large amount of information | into only the essentials.
3. An evaluation judges the value of something | and determines its worth.
4. Many species of plants and animals | are disappearing right before our eyes.
5. If we don't act fast, | it might be too late to save them.
6. Keep in mind that the writer's attitude | should always appropriately match the audience and the purpose.
7. Word stress: SUM·ma·rize, AN·a·lyze, SYN·the·size, e·VAL·u·ate, AU·di·ence.

Writing task

One topic, two paragraphs (based on lesson material 3.3, Exercise 3). Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words about a current event, or about a psychology topic you might use for your Unit 3 essay (for example, how stress affects students' exam performance, or why sleep matters for memory). You may also develop your paragraph from Lesson 18.

1. Before you write, note your **purpose** (summarize, analyze, synthesize or evaluate), your **audience** (for example, first-year psychology students) and the **tone** you want.
2. Write the paragraph with the topic sentence first and underline it.
3. Rewrite the paragraph with the topic sentence in a different position (at the end or in the middle).
4. Ask your tutor to find the topic sentence in each version without being told, and to say which version is more effective for your audience and why.

Self-editing checklist

- My purpose, audience and tone are written above the paragraph, and the paragraph matches them.
- The paragraph has one main idea, stated in a topic sentence with a controlling idea.
- My content (examples, statistics, facts, anecdotes, testimonies, observations) is appropriate and interesting for this audience.
- I defined any term that my audience may not know.
- My word choice, punctuation and sentence structure create the tone I chose, with no chat-style features.
- In the second version, the topic sentence is still clear in its new position.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Evaluation: the writer judges the film ("could easily have been cut down", "too ambitious") and gives advice ("read the book and give the movie a miss").
2. Summary: it retells the main events of the plot briefly, without judging the film.
3. Analysis: it separates the film into parts (music, acting, atmosphere, camera angles) and shows how they work together to create tension.

Exercise 2

1. The first paragraph goes to her parents; the second goes to her best friend.
2. Any three: the abbreviation "OMG"; many exclamation marks; slang ("peeps"); a word in capitals for emphasis ("NOT"); informal, complaining phrases ("forced me", "I was so bored"); a topic only friends care about (the basketball tournament). The first paragraph uses complete, neutral sentences and a responsible plan (rest, clear fluids).

Exercise 3 (example answers)

1. The writer is deeply concerned, alarmed and urgent: wildlife conservation is a serious and pressing matter.
2. Strong words ("disappearing right before our eyes", "devastating", "plummeted", "terrible destruction"); a warning ("If we don't act fast, it might be too late"); an emotional reference to our children ("for our children to see them in the wild"); statistics (7 percent of the tiger's historical range; from one hundred thousand in 1920 to a few thousand); a direct command ("Contact your local wildlife conservation society today").
3. To persuade readers to act to protect endangered species.

Exercise 4 (example answer)

- Topic sentence 1: Taking on-line classes allows working adults to earn a degree without giving up their jobs.
- Topic sentence 2: Taking on-line classes makes it harder for students to build relationships with their teachers and classmates.
- Difference: paragraph 1 would have a positive, encouraging tone and content about flexible schedules, saved travel time and examples of working students. Paragraph 2 would have a more critical, concerned tone and content about isolation, slow e-mail replies and missing class discussions.

Exercise 5 (example answers)

1. Clearly identifiable: it is the first sentence, "After reading the new TV guide this week, I had just one thought — we are still being bombarded with reality shows."
2. Yes. Each supporting sentence gives information about reality television, especially the new show *Prisoner*.

3. Only partly. Phrases such as "This season" and "Along with ..." link some ideas, but there are few transition words; a summarizing transition before the ending (for example, "All in all") would make the links clearer.
4. Yes. "We've had enough reality television to last us a lifetime!" repeats the main point (viewers are tired of reality shows) in different words.
5. The audience is blog readers, including TV producers ("if any of them are reading this blog"). The tone is informal, sarcastic and annoyed ("plague", "cursed", "mindless creation", "stop it!"). This suits a blog, but not an academic essay.

My notes